adversarial was his politics to its own that the BJP camp had conferred on him the moniker 'Maulana Mulayam'—the SP patriarch was held up as the very embodiment of Muslim appeasement politics, the oldest bugbear for saffronites. Now, however, on the home stretch to the 2024 election, the BJP has spied advantage in softening its stand on Uttar Pradesh's tallest OBC leader. Not only does it facilitate crossover support from the Yadavs, the largest OBC bloc in UP with at least 9 per cent of its population, it helps partly defang its most stout foe: the SP.

Naturally, the Padma Vibhushan googly put the SP in a state of confusion: it could neither praise the BJP for the honour nor denounce the decision. All that SP leaders, including Swami Prasad Maurya and Mulayam's daughter-in-law Dimple Yadav, could do was demand India's highest civilian award for Mulayam. "Netaji should have been given the Bharat Ratna, given his stature. The award should have come even much earlier. We will demand Bharat Ratna for Netaji," said Dimple in her statement. Maurya said the government has "made a mockery" of Mulayam's personality, work and contribution towards the nation. SP spokesperson Dr Ashutosh Verma also denies the BJP will make any electoral gains with what it sees as tokenism. "Whatever plan the BJP has in mind, it won't be able to make a dent among our supporters. Netaji was everyone's neta. He has respect across castes/communities," he says.

THE BJP NOW HAS THE TRICKY TASK OF BEING SOFT ON MULAYAM TO WOO THE LARGE OBC BLOC WHILE STAYING AGGRESSIVE ON SON AKHILESH

Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, though, thinks the bloc may not be that impermeable: "The BJP knows Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha polls are two different games. Though a large number of Yadavs vote for the SP in the assembly election, for the Lok Sabha, there are chances many of them could veer towards the BJP."

Top-down strategising has to filter through to the ground too, and there are hiccups there. A section of the local BJP is unhappy with the Centre's decision: it's difficult from them to reconcile the honour with the 'anti-Mulayam' politics they have pursued for decades. Says a senior BJP leader, "In 1990, several Hindutva supporters died in the police firing at Ayodhya. At that time, nobody could have imagined the man who ordered the police action would go on to be honoured with India's second-highest civilian award by the torch-bearers of the Ayodhya movement." The BJP also has the tricky task now of having to treat Mulayam with respect while staying aggressive on his son, Akhilesh Yadav. "Mulayam's death created sympathy for the SP in Yadav-dominated areas. That helped the party win the Mainpuri bypoll. We do not want to be seen as 'anti-Mulayam' but will target Akhilesh," says a party functionary.

BJP sources claim that in his late years, Mulayam had taken the edge off his attack on the BJP. In one of his Lok Sabha speeches, Mulayam had even made a generous statement about Prime Minister Narendra Modi: "*Modiji sabko saath lekar chalte hain, mujhe poora bharosa hai ki aap hi dobara* PM *banenge* (PM Modi believes in making everyone a stakeholder and I have no doubt he will become the PM again)." This, arguably, improved his bond with Modi, which now results in the Padma honour.

Secularism was also not Mulayam's primary calling card: that was Mandal politics. The mobilising of backward communities as a single political entity originated with him. His role in ending Congress domination is not discussed much, but the experiment he helmed along with BSP patriarch Kanshi Ram, giving a permanent voice to marginalised communities, created a profound disruption. How the BJP seeks to harvest that field from a safe ideological distance will be interesting to watch. ■

MADHYA PRADESH POLICE

SAY NO T

By Rahul Noronha

It's an aspect of servitude harking back to India's feudal and colonial days that Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan touched on while chairing a review meeting recently, as he cautioned Indian Police Service (IPS) officers in Madhya Pradesh against the excessive deployment of junior cops at their homes for domestic chores. The CM was reacting to news reports that suggested upwards of 30 police personnel were deployed at the home of a DIG-rank officer in state capital Bhopal. The officer in question has denied the reports, but this is not the first time the CM has flagged the issue. The IPS lobby continues to fiercely guard this 'privilege', but a large number of lower-rung police personnel are being denied the opportunity to perform core duties, leading to much discontent and resentment.

The MP Police, like their counterparts elsewhere, recruits constable tradesmen through its paramilitary arm Special Armed Forces (SAF). Besides those occupying technical posts, such as electrician, carpenter, driver and tailor, they comprise non-technical recruits—cooks, barbers, cobblers and sweepers. Originally supposed to make the SAF battalions self-sufficient, this army of constable tradesmen is ever-expanding, with the excess recruits among cooks, drivers and the like being diverted to the residences of senior officers to work as domestic helps. Official data shows about 11,000 constable tradesmen in MP. A rough estimate puts the number of those deployed on domestic duties at 5,500, or 50 per cent of that total.

It wasn't always like this. Since 1993, following an ex-